

DBT SKILLS WORKBOOK FOR TEENS

Manage Big Emotions with Confidence

Mindfulness + Distress Tolerance +
Emotion Regulation + Interpersonal Effectiveness

Daniel Tesfamariam

DBT Skills Workbook for Teens

Manage Big Emotions with Confidence

Copyright 2024 Daniel Tesfamariam. All rights reserved.

This workbook is for educational purposes only.

It is not a substitute for professional therapy.

If you are in crisis, text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).

WHAT IS DBT?

Dialectical Behavior Therapy teaches you skills to handle intense emotions without making things worse.

WHAT IS DBT?

DBT stands for Dialectical Behavior Therapy. It was created by Dr. Marsha Linehan to help people who experience very intense emotions.

'Dialectical' means holding two things that seem opposite at the same time:

- I am doing my best AND I can do better.
- I accept myself AND I want to change.
- This moment is painful AND it will pass.

DBT has FOUR main skill areas:

1. MINDFULNESS - Being present in the moment without judgment
2. DISTRESS TOLERANCE - Surviving crisis without making it worse
3. EMOTION REGULATION - Understanding and managing your feelings
4. INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS - Getting what you need from relationships

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK:

- Work through one section at a time
- Practice each skill before moving on
- There are no grades - this is for YOU
- It's okay to come back to skills you've already learned
- The more you practice, the more automatic these skills become

MINDFULNESS: OBSERVE

Observe means noticing without labeling or judging.

Like a camera - just record what's there.

EXERCISE: 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

5 things you can SEE:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

4 things you can TOUCH:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

3 things you can HEAR:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

2 things you can SMELL:

1. _____
2. _____

1 thing you can TASTE:

1. _____

How do you feel after this exercise? (1-10 calm): _____

MINDFULNESS: DESCRIBE

Describe means putting words to your experience - just the facts.

Instead of 'I'm angry' try 'I notice a hot feeling in my chest.'

EXERCISE: Describe Without Judging

Someone doesn't text you back. Describe the FACTS (not your story):

You get a bad grade. Describe what actually happened:

A friend cancels plans. Describe only what you observe:

JUDGMENT vs. DESCRIPTION:

Judgment

She's so rude

This is the worst day ever

I'm stupid

Nobody likes me

Everything is unfair

Description (rewrite)

MINDFULNESS: PARTICIPATE

Participate means fully throwing yourself into the moment.

Not watching from the sidelines - BEING in the experience.

EXERCISE: Mindful Activities Log

This week, try doing these activities with FULL attention:

- | | | |
|--|------------------|-------|
| ☐ Eating a meal (no phone) | How did it feel? | _____ |
| ☐ Listening to one full song with eyes closed | How did it feel? | _____ |
| ☐ Walking and noticing each step | How did it feel? | _____ |
| ☐ Having a conversation without multitasking | How did it feel? | _____ |
| ☐ Drawing or doodling for 5 minutes | How did it feel? | _____ |
| ☐ Doing one chore with full focus | How did it feel? | _____ |

My favorite mindful activity: _____

What I noticed when I was fully present:

DISTRESS TOLERANCE: TIPP SKILLS

When emotions hit 8-10 intensity, use TIPP to calm your body FAST:

T - Temperature

Hold ice cubes, splash cold water on face, or take a cold shower.

This activates the dive reflex and slows your heart rate.

I - Intense Exercise

Run, do jumping jacks, or sprint up stairs for 5-10 minutes.

Burns off the adrenaline your body is producing.

P - Paced Breathing

Breathe out LONGER than you breathe in (in 4, out 6-8).

Activates your parasympathetic nervous system.

P - Paired Muscle Relaxation

Tense each muscle group while breathing in, release while breathing out.

Tells your body: the danger has passed.

MY TIPP PLAN (fill in for YOUR crisis moments):

My T strategy: _____

My I strategy: _____

My P (breathing) strategy: _____

My P (muscle) strategy: _____

DISTRESS TOLERANCE: SELF-SOOTHE

Self-soothing means being KIND to yourself when you're hurting.

Build your personal self-soothe kit using all 5 senses:

SIGHT: What calms you to look at? (nature, art, photos, candles)

My choices:

1. _____ 2. _____

SOUND: What soothes you to hear? (music, rain, podcasts, silence)

My choices:

1. _____ 2. _____

SMELL: What scents comfort you? (candles, perfume, food, nature)

My choices:

1. _____ 2. _____

TASTE: What tastes bring comfort? (tea, chocolate, mints, fruit)

My choices:

1. _____ 2. _____

TOUCH: What feels good? (soft blanket, hot bath, fidget toy, pet)

My choices:

1. _____ 2. _____

MY SELF-SOOTHE KIT (items I will keep ready):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

DISTRESS TOLERANCE: PROS AND CONS		
When you want to act on urges, weigh the pros and cons FIRST.		
My urge/crisis behavior: _____		
PROS of resisting urge CONS of resisting urge		
After looking at this, my wisest choice is: _____ _____		

DISTRESS TOLERANCE: RADICAL ACCEPTANCE

Radical acceptance means accepting reality AS IT IS - not approving of it.

Pain + Non-acceptance = SUFFERING. Pain + Acceptance = just pain.

Things I cannot change (and need to accept):

Turning the Mind: When I catch myself fighting reality, I will:

ACCEPTANCE STATEMENTS (check ones that help you):

- ☐ This is what happened. I cannot change the past.
- ☐ Fighting reality doesn't change it - it only adds suffering.
- ☐ I can accept AND still work toward change.
- ☐ This moment is painful but it is not permanent.
- ☐ I didn't cause this, but I can choose how to respond.
- ☐ Acceptance is not approval.

EMOTION REGULATION: NAMING EMOTIONS

You can't manage what you can't name. Expand your emotion vocabulary!

ANGER family:	irritated, frustrated, annoyed, furious, bitter, resentful
SADNESS family:	disappointed, lonely, hopeless, grief, empty, heartbroken
FEAR family:	worried, anxious, panicked, terrified, insecure, nervous
JOY family:	content, excited, proud, grateful, peaceful, amused
SHAME family:	embarrassed, guilty, humiliated, inadequate, exposed
DISGUST family:	repulsed, contempt, judgmental, revolted

EMOTION LOG - Practice naming your emotions this week:

Day	Emotion Name	Intensity (1-10)	What triggered it?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

EMOTION REGULATION: OPPOSITE ACTION

When your emotion doesn't fit the facts, do the OPPOSITE of what it urges.

EMOTION	URGE	OPPOSITE ACTION
Sadness	Isolate, stay in bed	Get active, reach out to someone
Anger	Attack, yell	Gently avoid, take space, be kind
Fear	Run away, avoid	Approach what you fear (gradually)
Shame	Hide, don't tell anyone	Share with a trusted person
Guilt	Punish yourself	Repair, apologize, let it go

MY OPPOSITE ACTION PRACTICE:

Emotion I'm feeling: _____

Does this emotion fit the facts? (Y/N): _____

What is the urge? _____

What is the opposite action? _____

Did I do it? What happened?

EMOTION REGULATION: ABC PLEASE

Reduce vulnerability to negative emotions by taking care of basics:

A - Accumulate Positives

Do one pleasant thing each day (small counts!)

B - Build Mastery

Do something that gives you a sense of accomplishment

C - Cope Ahead

Plan how you'll handle difficult situations before they happen

PLEASE skills (body basics that affect emotions):

PL - Physical illness

Treat it. Take medication. See a doctor.

E - Eating

Eat regularly. Don't skip meals. Balanced food.

A - Avoid mood-altering substances

No drugs/alcohol to cope.

S - Sleep

7-9 hours. Consistent schedule. Good sleep hygiene.

E - Exercise

20+ minutes most days. Anything that moves your body.

MY PLEASE CHECK-IN THIS WEEK:

Day	Slept?	Ate?	Moved?	Pleasant?	Mastery?
Mon	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Tue	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Wed	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Thu	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Fri	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Sat	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____
Sun	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	_____	_____

EMOTION REGULATION: WEEKLY TRACKER

Track your emotions daily. Notice patterns over time.

Week of: ____/____/____

Day	Strongest Emotion	Intensity	Trigger	Skill Used
Mon	_____	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____	_____

Patterns I notice:

INTERPERSONAL: DEAR MAN

Use DEAR MAN when you need to ASK for something or SAY NO:

D - Describe	State the facts of the situation (no judgments)
E - Express	Share how you feel using 'I' statements
A - Assert	Ask clearly for what you want or say no clearly
R - Reinforce	Explain why it benefits them to help/agree
M - Mindful	Stay focused. Don't get sidetracked
A - Appear confident	Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall
N - Negotiate	Be willing to give to get. Offer alternatives

MY DEAR MAN SCRIPT (write it out before the conversation):

Describe: _____

Express: _____

Assert: _____

Reinforce: _____

How will I stay Mindful? _____

What am I willing to negotiate? _____

INTERPERSONAL: GIVE SKILLS

Use GIVE when you want to maintain the RELATIONSHIP:

- | | |
|------------------------|--|
| G - Gentle | No attacks, threats, or judging. Be respectful. |
| I - Interested | Listen. Ask questions. Don't interrupt. |
| V - Validate | Acknowledge their feelings even if you disagree. |
| E - Easy Manner | Smile. Use humor. Be light when possible. |

PRACTICE: Think of a recent conflict. Rewrite your approach using GIVE:

The situation:	_____
Gentle:	_____
Interested:	_____
Validate:	_____
Easy manner:	_____

INTERPERSONAL: FAST SKILLS

Use FAST when you want to maintain your SELF-RESPECT:

F - Fair

Be fair to yourself AND the other person.

A - Apologies (no excessive)

Don't over-apologize. Don't apologize for existing.

S - Stick to values

Don't sell out your values to be liked.

T - Truthful

Don't lie or exaggerate. Be honest.

MY VALUES (things I won't compromise on):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Times I over-apologize:

What I will say INSTEAD of sorry:

INTERPERSONAL: SAYING NO

Saying no is a complete sentence. But here are scripts if you need them:

'Thanks for thinking of me, but I can't this time.'

'I need to check my schedule. I'll get back to you.' (buys time)

'That doesn't work for me, but here's what I can do...'

'I'm not comfortable with that.'

'I have a rule about that.' (you don't need to explain the rule)

PRACTICE: Write your own 'no' scripts for common situations:

When friends pressure you to do something risky:

My script: _____

When someone asks too much of your time:

My script: _____

When you need to set a boundary with family:

My script: _____

MY CRISIS SURVIVAL KIT

Fill this out NOW while you're calm. Use it when emotions hit 8+.

People I can call/text:

Places I feel safe:

Things that distract me:

Songs that calm me down:

Reminders that this will pass:

My TIPP plan:

Professional help numbers:

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988

MY DBT SKILLS TOOLBOX

Circle or highlight the skills that work BEST for you:

MINDFULNESS:

5-4-3-2-1 grounding, describe without judgment, participate fully

DISTRESS TOLERANCE:

TIPP, self-soothe, pros/cons, radical acceptance

EMOTION REGULATION:

Name it, opposite action, ABC PLEASE, check the facts

INTERPERSONAL:

DEAR MAN, GIVE, FAST, saying no scripts

My TOP 3 go-to skills:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Skill I want to practice more: _____

When I will practice: _____

WEEKLY PRACTICE LOG - Week 1

Week of: ____/____/____

Day	Skill Practiced	Situation	Helpful? (1-10)
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

This week I'm proud of:

Next week I want to focus on:

WEEKLY PRACTICE LOG - Week 2

Week of: ____/____/____

Day	Skill Practiced	Situation	Helpful? (1-10)
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

This week I'm proud of:

Next week I want to focus on:

WEEKLY PRACTICE LOG - Week 3

Week of: ____/____/____

Day	Skill Practiced	Situation	Helpful? (1-10)
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

This week I'm proud of:

Next week I want to focus on:
